

12-city tournament in UP, visiting multiple schools and hosting cricket camps. We'll identify talented girls from these camps, bring them to our pre-season training, and help them gain exposure," she added.

While these grassroots initiatives are crucial for a budding league, adapting to the new four-city caravan model presents its own challenges. Many teams had selected players at the auction assuming matches would remain confined to Mumbai and Bengaluru.

"The auctions were completed in December before the league's expansion to four cities was finalised. So, getting the right combination will be critical," said a franchise insider.

Royal Challengers Bengaluru, the defending champion, will once again play at home. Smriti Mandhana and her team face the challenge of meeting high expectations after retaining their core squad and making strategic additions during the mini-auction.

The team acquired leg-spinner Prema Rawat, Kerala pacer Joshitha VJ, and seasoned campaigner Renuka Singh Thakur to bolster its pace attack. The inclusion of Jagravi Pawar and Raghvi Bist adds further depth.

Meanwhile, Gujarat Giants will rely on its marquee overseas player Deandra Dottin, the most expensive international signing, and the

Curtain-raiser: The new Kotambi Stadium in Vadodara will host the WPL opener this year. VIJAY SONEJI